

Tensor Products on Quantum Spin Systems

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In the 1960s Friedrichs met Heisenberg, and used the occasion to express to him the deep gratitude of the community of mathematicians for having created quantum mechanics, which gave birth to the beautiful theory of operators in Hilbert space. Heisenberg allowed that this was so; Friedrichs then added that the mathematicians have, in some measure, returned the favor. Heisenberg looked non-committal, so Friedrichs pointed out that it was a mathematician, von Neumann, who clarified the difference between a self-adjoint operator and one that is merely symmetric. “What’s the difference,” said Heisenberg. [1]

What is a particle?

First, **To write introduction**

I. THE QUASI-LOCAL ALGEBRA

In the previous semester, we constructed our observable algebra in a rather ad hoc manner: We declared that we had an algebra $\mathcal{A}(\mathcal{O})$ for each region of spacetime $\mathcal{O}$. Then, we considered only algebras for which the asymptotic abelianness condition held.

However, this ostensibly presents a number of conditions which our algebras have to fulfil. It no longer suffices to write down a model — we have to then verify that the associated C^* algebra satisfies these conditions. Instead, we will proceed with a more formal construction of the *quasi-local algebra* as defined in [2], and show that it satisfies all the conditions we seek.

Definition 1 (Quasi-Local Algebra). A quasi-local algebra is a C^* algebra $\mathcal{A}$ and a net of C^* algebras $\{\mathcal{A}_\alpha\}_{\alpha \in I}$ such that the net I has an orthogonality relation $\perp$ and that satisfies

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the following conditions.

1. If $\alpha \geq \beta$, then $\mathcal{A}_\alpha \supseteq \mathcal{A}_\beta$.
2. $\mathcal{A} = \overline{\cup_\alpha \mathcal{A}_\alpha}$, where the bar denotes norm closure.
3. The algebras $\mathcal{A}_\alpha$ all share an identity element $\mathbb{1}$.
4. There exists an automorphism σ with $\sigma^2 = \mathbb{1}$, such that $\sigma(\mathcal{A}_\alpha) = \mathcal{A}_\alpha$ and

$$[\mathcal{A}_\alpha^e, \mathcal{A}_\beta^e] = [\mathcal{A}_\alpha^e, \mathcal{A}_\beta^o] = \{\mathcal{A}_\alpha^o, \mathcal{A}_\beta^o\} = \{0\}$$

whenever $\alpha \perp \beta$, and $\mathcal{A}_\alpha^e$ and $\mathcal{A}_\beta^e$ are the even and odd elements with respect to σ (meaning those elements with $\sigma(A) = A$ or $\sigma(A) = -A$ respectively)

This definition requires a significant amount of unpacking. First, we have an index set for the algebras. In many applications of physics, this will be include subsets of spacetime, $I \subseteq \mathcal{P}(\mathbb{R}^n)$. They will be ordered by inclusion, and we will declare two subsets orthogonal if they are disjoint.

The last condition also requires some explanation. Essentially, if we have two bosonic operators that are spacetime separated, we expect that they commute; while if we have fermionic operators, we expect that they anticommute. Thus, even asymptotically, we must distinguish between these two types. The automorphism takes care of this; in some sense, the even elements represent the bosonic operators and the even ones the fermionic operators.

Having constructed appropriate algebras for each region of spacetime, we then find the quasi-local algebra by taking the norm closure of their union.

In this talk, we will mostly work with spin systems. In a spin system, we have as our spacetime $\mathbb{Z}^n$ instead of $\mathbb{R}^n$. Physically, these could represent atoms, and the electrons can only hop between these atoms. We call this a tight binding model. The C^* algebra for a single spin is also given by the 2×2 matrices.

Example 2. The Heisenberg model consists of a lattice of spins as pictured in Fig. 1. Each spin interacts with each other through a Hamiltonian

$$H = J \sum_{\langle ij \rangle} \vec{S}_i \cdot \vec{S}_j$$

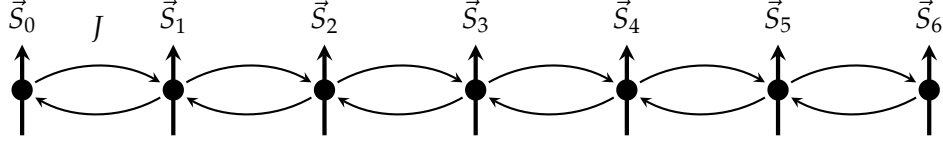


FIG. 1. The Heisenberg model in 1 dimension is pictured. At each lattice site, there is a single spin; an energy penalty J is applied for every two spins that are pointing in the same direction.

where $\langle ij \rangle$ means that they are only summed over if i and j are neighbours. It can be shown that the ground state of this model is ferromagnetic for $J < 0$ and antiferromagnetic for $J > 0$.

II. DYNAMICS OF QUANTUM SYSTEMS

Having the algebra, we must next be able to define the dynamics of a quantum system. While it is possible to define the dynamics using a Hamiltonian in the GNS representation, this defeats the purpose of the algebraic approach to quantum mechanics. Thus, we seek with a purely C^* algebraic way to generate dynamics. Let us begin with the goal:

Definition 3. A time evolution on a C^* algebra $\mathcal{A}$ is an function $\alpha : \mathcal{A} \times \mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathcal{A}$, that we denote as α_t , such that each α_t is an automorphism.

In the case where $\mathcal{A}$ has the form $\mathcal{B}(\mathcal{H})$, we can prove that the automorphisms are *inner*, meaning that they can be represented as a unitary time evolution

$$\alpha_t(A) = U(t)AU(t)^*.$$

Then, using Stone's theorem, we can represent U as an exponential $\exp(itH)$, yielding our Hamiltonian. However, this requires a Hilbert space, and hence is not desirable. Instead, the generator of dynamics on a C^* algebra is known as a *derivation*:

Definition 4. A derivation δ of a C^* algebra is a linear map defined on a $*$ -subalgebra $D(\delta)$, $\delta : D(\delta) \rightarrow \mathcal{A}$ such that

1. $\delta(A^*) = \delta(A)^*$ for $A \in D(\delta)$

2. $\delta(AB) = \delta(A)B + A\delta(B)$ for $A, B \in D(\delta)$.

Essentially, the product rule suffices to define a derivative. This is reminiscent of differential geometry, where the tangent space is defined using derivations in a very similar manner.

This construction satisfies many of the properties we might expect. We will state a few examples without proof.

Example 5. Consider a C^* algebra $\mathcal{A}$ with a strongly continuous 1 parameter group of automorphisms α_t , meaning that $t \mapsto \alpha_t(A)$ is strongly continuous for each A . Then

$$\delta(A) = \lim_{t \rightarrow 0} \left(\frac{\alpha_t(A) - A}{t} \right)$$

is a derivation, defined on the points where the limit exists.

In a unitary time evolution on a Hilbert space, the corresponding derivation is given by the commutator as we might expect.

Example 6. Consider $\mathcal{A} = \mathcal{B}(\mathcal{H})$ and let α_t be a 1 parameter group of automorphisms given by conjugation:

$$\alpha_t(A) = e^{itH} A e^{-itH}$$

for self-adjoint H . Then the corresponding derivation is given by

$$\delta(A) = i[H, A].$$

Now that we have defined derivations, we move forward to define interactions.

Definition 7. Consider a quantum spin system defined on a set of sites Γ . An interaction Φ is a mapping $\Phi : \mathcal{P}(\Gamma) \rightarrow \mathcal{A}$ such that $\Phi(\Lambda) \in \mathcal{A}(\Lambda)$ and $\Phi(\Lambda)$ is self adjoint.

Example 8. In the Heisenberg model, we have

$$\Phi(\{x, y\}) = \begin{cases} J & \langle xy \rangle \\ 0 & \text{otherwise.} \end{cases}$$

We recall again that we are working with *spin systems*. This will become important here. In particular, it is important that the algebra on each site is finite. That means, if

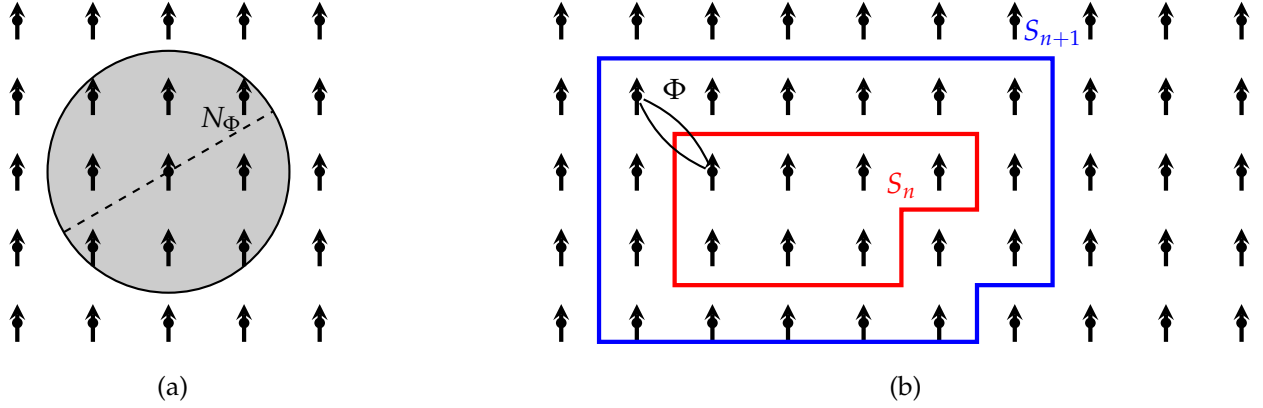


FIG. 2. Structure of local interactions. **(a)** If the interaction is local, there is a number N_Φ such that $\Phi(X)$ is only nonzero for sets smaller than N_Φ (as pictured). **(b)** Given an observable with support in the set S_n , application of the commutator allows for interactions within slightly wider sets, as shown in S_{n+1} .

Λ is bounded, then $\Phi(\Lambda)$ is finite dimensional. Thus, for each Λ , we can construct a *bounded* Hamiltonian via

$$H(\Lambda) = \sum_{X \subseteq \Lambda} \Phi(X).$$

In addition, the interactions will also often be *finite range*, meaning that $\Phi(X) = 0$ for sets larger than a certain diameter, say $|X| > N_\Phi$. If the interaction is finite range, then the sum of the local Hamiltonians induce a derivation, because

$$\delta^n(A) = i \lim_{\Lambda \rightarrow \infty} [H_\Lambda, A]$$

only has finitely many terms where H_Λ intersects A .

We will call the C^* algebra the local algebra $\mathcal{A}_{\text{loc}}$ and the corresponding Hamiltonians the local Hamiltonians. Because of this, we can then show the time evolution for local systems, which we will state without proof:

Theorem 9. Let Φ be a finite range interaction and δ the corresponding derivation. Then the local algebra $\mathcal{A}_{\text{loc}}$ is analytic, meaning that $\exp(t\delta)(A)$ exists for all $A \in \mathcal{A}_{\text{loc}}$ and sufficiently small t .

Proof. Essentially we want to bound $\|\delta^n(A)\|$. In expectation that the locality of A will be important, we define a *finite* set Λ such that $A \in \mathcal{A}(\Lambda)$. If there existed a Hamiltonian

H corresponding to the interaction, we would have

$$\delta^n(A) = i^n [H, [\dots, [H, A]]].$$

However, there is no Hamiltonian for the entire interaction. However, the finite range nature of the interaction now comes into play. For example, in the first commutator, we would have

$$\delta(A) = i \sum_{X_1 | X_1 \cap \Lambda \neq \emptyset} [\Phi(X_1), A].$$

Here, the locality of the algebra means that the commutator is only nonvanishing for X_1 that intersect Λ , and thus we only need to consider these sets. Because Λ is finite, the number of possible X_1 is also finite, and thus the sum must be finite. In the general case, we define $S_1 = \Lambda$ and $S_k = S_{k-1} \cup X_{k-1}$ for $k > 1$ (see Fig. 2). Then,

$$\delta^n(A) = i^n \sum_{X_1 \cap S_1 \neq \emptyset} \cdots \sum_{X_n \cap S_n \neq \emptyset} [\Phi(X_n), [\dots, [\Phi(X_1), A]]].$$

The missing ingredient is a bound on the number of possible subsets X_n . Since the interaction is finite range, there is a constant N_Φ such that it suffices to consider X_n with $|X_n| \leq N_\Phi$. Thus, we have

$$\|\delta^n(A)\| \leq 2^n \|A\| \prod_{k=1}^n ((k-1)(N_\Phi - 1) + |\Lambda|) \|\Phi\|^n.$$

By a simple computation, it follows that

$$\|\delta^n(A)\| \leq \|A\| n! e^{\lambda(|\Lambda|+1-N_\Phi)} \left(\frac{2\|\Phi\| e^{\lambda(N_\Phi-1)}}{\lambda} \right)^n.$$

Thus, the exponential exists for sufficiently small t . □

Now that we have constructed the exponential for local observables, we must extend it to the entire quasi-local algebra in the following theorem:

Theorem 10. There exists a one parameter group of automorphisms α_t on the quasi-local algebra $\mathcal{A}$.

Proof. We will extend the group as follows. First, we will begin with an interaction on a finite region. This will allow us to show isometry, which will then provide an extension to the quasi local algebra using well known results. Finally, we will extend the domain of t from a neighbourhood of the origin to the entire real line.

We begin by defining $\delta_\Lambda(A) = i[H_\Lambda, A]$ for a finite subset Λ of the sites. We also begin with a local operator $A \in \mathcal{A}(X)$. For each $\Lambda \supseteq X$, the derivations $\delta^n(A)$ and $\delta_\Lambda^n(A)$ will agree for $n \leq N(\Lambda)$, where $N(\Lambda)$ is some function depending on Λ . Thus, we have

$$\|\alpha_t^\Lambda(A) - \alpha_t(A)\| = \left\| \sum_{n=N(\Lambda)}^{\infty} \left(\frac{t^n \delta_\Lambda^n(A)}{n!} - \frac{t^n \delta^n(A)}{n!} \right) \right\|.$$

Note that $N(\Lambda) \xrightarrow{\Lambda \rightarrow \infty} \infty$. **Complete proof later** □

Now that dynamics have been defined, the final ingredient we need is to define ground states.

III. GROUND STATES

Ground states are states of minimal energy. Since this does not affect the dynamics, we can always shift the zero of energy such that the ground state has zero energy. Thus, ground states do not evolve in time. This leads us to our formal definition

Definition 11. Let α_t be a 1 parameter group of automorphisms on a C^* algebra $\mathcal{A}$. Then a ground state ω is a state such that $\omega \circ \alpha_t = \omega$ for all t and if $H_\omega \geq 0$ in the corresponding GNS representation.

However, this definition is clearly unwieldy, not least because we need to explicitly construct the Hamiltonian in the GNS representation. Instead, we seek another characterisation of ground states, which we will state without proof

Theorem 12. Let ω be a state on $\mathcal{A}$ and α_t a strongly continuous 1 parameter group of automorphisms. Then the following are equivalent

1. ω is a ground state.
2. $-i\omega(A^*\delta(A)) \geq 0$ for all $A \in D(\delta)$.

It is then finally time to discuss one of the system that characterised research in the 2000s.

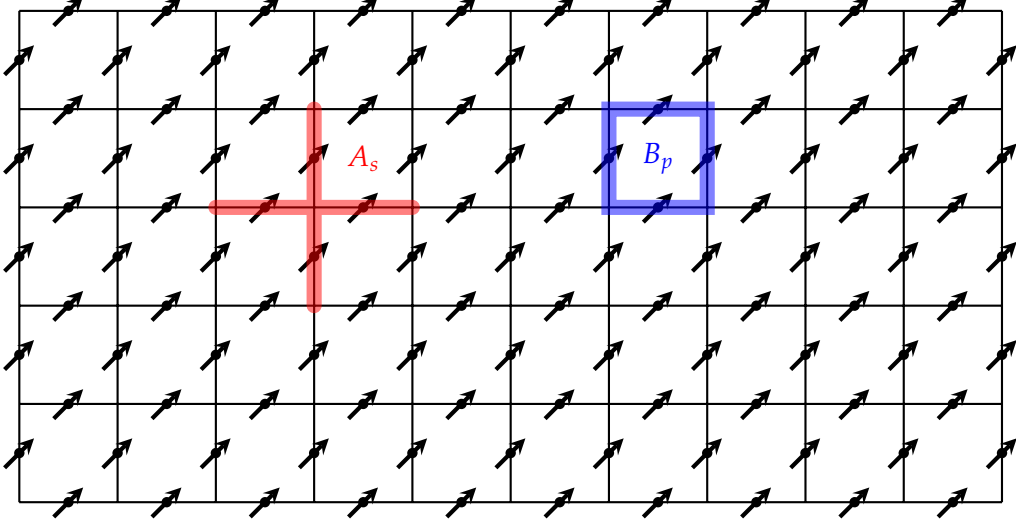


FIG. 3. The toric code consists of a square lattice. A spin degree of freedom lies on each *bond*. The support of the operators A_s and B_p are also drawn.

IV. THE TORIC CODE

The Toric code, first proposed by Kitaev [3] in 1997, remains a paradigmatic model of topological physics. It is defined on a square lattice, with a spin degree of freedom on each *edge*. We then define two operators, one defined on a “star” and one on a plaquette (see Fig. 3):

$$A_s = \bigotimes_{j \in s} \sigma_j^x, \quad B_p = \bigotimes_{j \in p} \sigma_j^z.$$

We note that $A_s^2 = B_p^2 = \mathbb{1}$, and that $[A_s, B_p] = 0$ for all stars s and plaquettes p . In particular, the eigenvalues of A_s and B_p are ± 1 . Now we seek a ground state. Let us begin by showing that A_s and B_p are *stabilisers*.

Lemma 13. Let $\mathcal{A}$ be a unital C^* algebra, ω a state on $\mathcal{A}$. Define $X \in \mathcal{A}$ such that $X = X^*$, $\omega(X) = 1$ and $I - X$ is positive. Then for all $Y \in \mathcal{A}$ we have $\omega(XY) = \omega(YX) = \omega(Y)$.

Proof. Because $\mathbb{1} - X$ is positive, we can take the square root $\sqrt{\mathbb{1} - X}$. Then, we have

$$\begin{aligned} |\omega((\mathbb{1} - X)Y)|^2 &= |\omega(\sqrt{\mathbb{1} - X} \sqrt{\mathbb{1} - X} Y)|^2 \\ &\leq \omega(\mathbb{1} - X) \omega(Y^* (\mathbb{1} - X) Y) = 0 \end{aligned}$$

where we used the Cauchy-Schwarz inequality before finding that $\omega(\mathbb{1} - X) = 0$. Similarly, we can show that $\omega(Y(\mathbb{1} - X)) = 0$. Thus, by the linearity of states, we find that $\omega(XY) = \omega(YX) = \omega(Y)$. $\square$

Now, we show the stabiliser property of A_s and B_p :

Theorem 14. Let ω be a state on $\mathcal{A}$ such that $\omega(A_s) = \omega(B_p) = 1$ for all s and p . Then ω is a ground state.

Proof. Again, we consider a local $A \in \mathcal{A}(\Lambda)$. Then, the derivation is given by

$$\delta(A) = -i \sum_{s \cap \Lambda \neq \emptyset} [A_s, A] - i \sum_{p \cap \Lambda \neq \emptyset} [B_p, A]$$

where we have summed over the stars s and the plaquettes p intersecting Λ . We seek to use Theorem 12 to prove that ω is a ground state. Thus, we expand

$$-i\omega(A^*\delta(A)) = \sum_{s \cap \Lambda \neq \emptyset} \omega(A^*AA_s) - \omega(A^*A_sA) + \sum_{p \cap \Lambda \neq \emptyset} \omega(A^*AB_p) - \omega(A^*B_pA).$$

However, using the previous lemma and the condition that $\omega(A_s) = 1$, we can write $\omega(A^*AA_s) = \omega(A^*A)$ and thus

$$\omega(A^*A) - \omega(A^*A_sA) = \omega(A^*(\mathbb{1} - A_s)A) \geq 0.$$

Thus, we find that the expression is positive, and ω is then a ground state. $\square$

Now, we reach the most interesting part of this presentation, which will be the equivalence of the toric code to a classical spin system. We will begin by defining an abelian subalgebra of $\mathcal{A}$.

Definition 15. The classical algebra of the toric code is defined by

$$\mathcal{A}_{\text{cl}} = \mathcal{A}(\{A_s\}, \{B_p\})$$

i.e. it is the algebra generated by the operators A_s and B_p .

As we now know, a classical C^* algebra admits a realisation as a set of continuous functions via the Gel'fand transformation [4]. Since the eigenvalues of A_s and B_p are ± 1 , a character must send each element to ± 1 . Thus, a homomorphism $\chi : \mathcal{A}_{\text{cl}} \rightarrow \mathbb{C}$

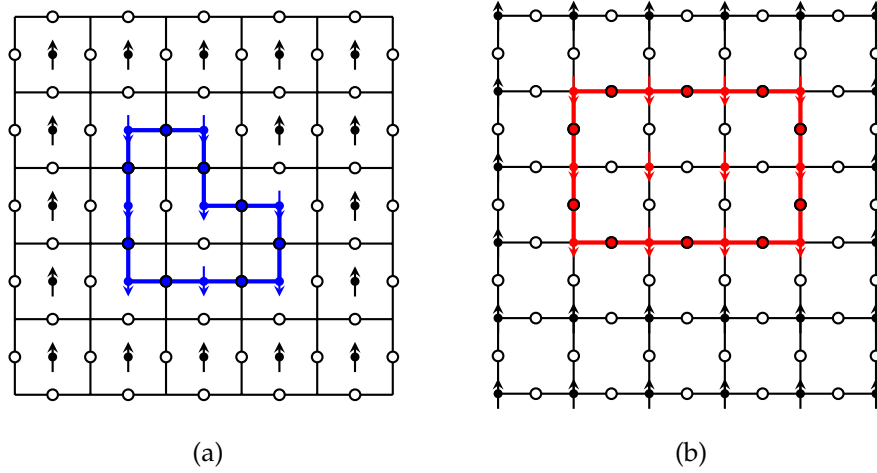


FIG. 4. Loop gas of the toric code corresponds to an Ising model. **(a)** The spins corresponding to the plaquettes, when flipped, create a loop defined on the *dual* lattice to the square lattice. **(b)** The spins corresponding to the stars create a loop within the original square lattice when flipped.

can be uniquely defined by giving $\chi(A_s)$ and $\chi(B_p)$ a value in $\{-1, 1\}$ for each s and p . This can be interpreted as mapping each star and plaquette into a spin. Thus, the spins and plaquettes correspond to Ising models. This can be understood as interpreting the ground state as a *loop gas* as depicted in Fig. 4.

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